

3.2 The Seven-Layer Character Excavation Framework

Complete all seven layers in order for each character. Aim for five to eight voice-relevant traits per layer. Apply the Voice Filter (section 3.3) to every entry before writing it into your profile.

3.2.1 Layer One: Surface Mannerisms Worksheet

Purpose: Capture the observable speech behaviors a reader would notice on the page. These are the fingerprints of your character's voice.

Character: [CHARACTER_NAME]

Guiding questions if you stall: *What would this character's best friend notice about the way they talk? What would a stranger on a bus pick up on in thirty seconds?*

#	Observable Speech Behavior	Example Line (one sentence the character might say demonstrating this behavior)
1	[E.G., "Interrupts midsentence"]	[E.G., "Look, I don't—no, forget it. Just go."]
2	[BEHAVIOR]	[EXAMPLE_LINE]
3	[BEHAVIOR]	[EXAMPLE_LINE]
4	[BEHAVIOR]	[EXAMPLE_LINE]
5	[BEHAVIOR]	[EXAMPLE_LINE]
6	[OPTIONAL]	[OPTIONAL]
7	[OPTIONAL]	[OPTIONAL]
8	[OPTIONAL]	[OPTIONAL]

3.2.2 Layer Two: Communication History Worksheet

Purpose: Connect each surface mannerism to its origin. This gives the AI the causal logic that determines how speech shifts under different pressures.

Character: [CHARACTER_NAME]

Surface Mannerism (from Layer One)	Origin Story / Communication History	How This Root Shifts the Behavior Under Different Pressures
[E.G., "Interrupts midsentence"]	[E.G., "Talked over as a child; learned to seize the sentence or lose it"]	[E.G., "Under romantic vulnerability: interrupts softly, then apologizes. Under professional anger: interrupts sharply, does not apologize."]
[MANNERISM]	[ORIGIN]	[SHIFT_UNDER_PRESSURE]
[MANNERISM]	[ORIGIN]	[SHIFT_UNDER_PRESSURE]
[MANNERISM]	[ORIGIN]	[SHIFT_UNDER_PRESSURE]
[MANNERISM]	[ORIGIN]	[SHIFT_UNDER_PRESSURE]

3.2.3 Layer Three: Emotional Defense Mechanisms Worksheet

Purpose: Document the tactical strategies the character uses to protect themselves when conversation approaches their core wound. Each defense produces a distinct, identifiable shift in speech.

Character: [CHARACTER_NAME]

Defense Strategy	Trigger Situation	Linguistic Shift (what changes in the speech)	Example Line
[E.G., "Deflects with sarcasm"]	[E.G., "Someone asks about his childhood"]	[E.G., "Vocabulary sharpens; sentences become cutting and rhythmic; humor masks pain"]	[E.G., "Oh, you want the origin story? Fine. Boy meets disappointment. Boy becomes disappointment. The end."]
[STRATEGY]	[TRIGGER]	[LINGUISTIC_SHIFT]	[EXAMPLE]
[STRATEGY]	[TRIGGER]	[LINGUISTIC_SHIFT]	[EXAMPLE]
[STRATEGY]	[TRIGGER]	[LINGUISTIC_SHIFT]	[EXAMPLE]

3.2.4 Layer Four: Relational Triggers Worksheet

Purpose: Identify the specific conversational situations that cause the character's default speech to break or intensify. Each trigger becomes a conditional rule in your Dialogue Matrix.

Character: [CHARACTER_NAME]

#	Trigger Situation (what happens in the scene)	Speech Shift (what changes in the voice)	Conditional Rule (write as: "When [trigger], this character's speech becomes [shift]")
1	[E.G., "Asked a direct emotional question"]	[E.G., "Sentences shorten to 1–3 words; vocabulary narrows to monosyllables; turns away"]	[E.G., "When asked a direct emotional question, this character's speech becomes monosyllabic, clipped, and physically avoidant."]
2	[TRIGGER]	[SPEECH_SHIFT]	[CONDITIONAL_RULE]
3	[TRIGGER]	[SPEECH_SHIFT]	[CONDITIONAL_RULE]
4	[OPTIONAL]	[SPEECH_SHIFT]	[CONDITIONAL_RULE]

3.2.5 Layer Five: Core Wound Excavation

Purpose: Name the deepest psychological injury governing the character's emotional baseline. This is the single most important layer for subtext.

Character: [CHARACTER_NAME]

1. The Wound Belief: In one sentence, what does this character believe about themselves that was installed by their deepest injury?

[YOUR_ANSWER — E.G., "My needs are an inconvenience to the people I love."]

2. The Conversational Cost: How does holding this belief make every act of speaking more difficult, more effortful, or more guarded?

[YOUR_ANSWER — E.G., "Every sentence that expresses a want costs enormous effort. He minimizes his own desires to reduce the burden he believes he imposes."]

3. The Linguistic Fingerprint: What specific, repeatable speech pattern does this wound produce? Name the vocabulary shift, sentence-length change, or tonal quality.

[YOUR_ANSWER — E.G., "Requests emerge as clipped, reluctant fragments. 'Stay, then' rather than 'I need you to stay.' Apologetic brevity. A shrug baked into the syntax."]

4. The Subtext Test: Write one line of dialogue where the wound is visible beneath the words. Then write the same line as the character wishes they could say it, without the wound filtering it.

- **Wound-filtered:** [E.G., "Stay, then."]
- **Unfiltered wish:** [E.G., "Please don't go. I need you here. I can't do this alone."]

The gap between these two lines is your subtext engine. Every scene where the reader senses what the character cannot say draws its power from this distance.

3.2.6 Layer Six: Aspirational Self-Image Worksheet

Purpose: Define the mask the character wears in conversation and the specific linguistic choices that maintain it. The gap between the mask and the wound is where subtext lives.

Character: [CHARACTER_NAME]

Field	Your Entry
The mask in three words:	[E.G., "Unbothered. Efficient. Final."]
How the character wants their words to land:	[E.G., "Like a door closing: final, clean, no echo."]
Linguistic choices that maintain the mask:	[E.G., "Short declarative sentences. No hedging. No softening qualifiers. Ends exchanges before the other person can respond."]
What the mask hides:	[E.G., "The core wound: the belief that his needs are an inconvenience."]
The gap the reader senses:	[E.G., "He sounds final, but the reader feels the effort it costs him to keep the sentence short."]

3.2.7 Layer Seven: Hidden Contradictions Worksheet

Purpose: Map the exact moment the mask fails and the precise linguistic inversion that follows. These contradictions are the moments readers screenshot and share.

Character: [CHARACTER_NAME]

Guiding question if you stall: *What is the one emotion this character cannot perform their way through?*

Field	Your Entry
The mask (from Layer Six):	[E.G., "Formal, polysyllabic, controlled."]
The breaking point:	[E.G., "Genuine fear. A moment where control is impossible."]

Field	Your Entry
The linguistic inversion (what the speech becomes):	[E.G., "Formality collapses. Contractions vanish. Sentences revert to childlike brevity: 'No. No, please. Stay.'"]
Example line showing the crack:	[E.G., "I can't—I can't do the—the thing where I pretend. Just. Stay. Please."]
What the reader feels in this moment:	[E.G., "The wall he built for thirty chapters just fell. And he sounds nine years old."]